

Speaker 1: Thank you very much, I will send a consent form on [Social Media] after the interview ends, which basically asks if you accept or not that the interview be recorded and then which of the three options you want for the transcription, whether you accept that all your answers be used or not, and which answers you don't want to be used. Then after the interview, you'll have more time to respond to this, right? Because you may choose to remove something or not, but it's a very calm interview, very simple, with questions about relationships in general, and then about your current relationship or previous relationships. If you don't want to answer any question, you can just ask me to move to the next one, and that's okay. Is that alright?

Speaker 2: You are [Professor] student, right?

Speaker 1: Sorry, I forgot to introduce myself, I'm [Speaker 1], a psychology student, doing scientific initiation in the laboratory that [Professor] coordinates. This research is about relationship quality and is being conducted by one of [Professor]'s PhD students. We are assisting with the interviews, and this research is by a professor from the [Country A], being conducted in five countries, and [Country B] is one of them. This PhD student is collecting data from all over [Country B]. We need a lot of people, and it's very important that people agree to participate in an interview. For example, it's online and synchronous, which is quite difficult. Alright. Can we start?

Speaker 2: Yes.

Speaker 1: I'd like to know how old you

Speaker 2: I'm [51-55] years old.

Speaker 1: And how long have you and your wife been together?

Speaker 2: Altogether, now in [Month], it will be [26-30] years.

Speaker 1: Nice, a long time. Do you have children?

Speaker 2: We have [1-5].

Speaker 1: How old are they?

Speaker 2: You might find it strange, but one is [31-40]. Actually, she had a daughter from her first relationship, but she's my daughter too, and the youngest is [16-20].

Speaker 1: Nice. And do you all live together? Who do you live with?

Speaker 2: No, our eldest daughter doesn't live with us, she's married and currently lives in [Country C].

Speaker 1: Oh, that's nice

Speaker 2: The youngest lives with us, yes.

Speaker 1: I see. And what is your main source of income and your current job?

Speaker 2: I have two sources of income that are quite similar in terms of value. One is from the university, I am a [Job] at [University A] in the [Program], and I also work for a [Job B]. I work in the [Topic].

Speaker 1: I see. Interesting. And can I refer to your wife as your wife, or do you prefer I call her by her name or another name? I'll call her by her name, [Partner].

Speaker 2: [Partner], alright.

Speaker 1: I'd like you to tell me the story of your relationship, how you met, the beginning of your dating, your encounters.

Speaker 2: We met at a [Event], an off-season carnival. At that time, I lived in [City A], [Country D]. We met there and a few days later, we started dating. This was in January [Year], and since then, we've been together. We officially got married in [Month] [Year], [1-5] year and [6-10] months later. In [Year], we moved to [City B] and have lived here ever since.

Speaker 1: Nice. [Year] is the year I was born. Now I'd like you to think about the relationships of some friends or people you know. How would you rate the quality of your relationship with [Partner] compared to your friends' relationships? In your judgment, do you believe yours is better or worse? Why?

Speaker 2: It's difficult to judge others' relationships, but from what we can observe, I think our relationship is better in many aspects. One of the main reasons is that even in our society, which is still very machista, we have a lot of partnership in our relationship in various aspects and decision-making. It wasn't always like this in the beginning, especially, but for a long time now, everything that concerns professional matters and day-to-day issues, we try to seek a balance so that neither is prioritized over the other when possible. Sometimes it's necessary, especially in the beginning. But generally, we try to find this balance. For example, at the start of our careers, opportunities might appear more for one than the other, which happened to us. In the beginning, more opportunities came to me, which is why we moved to [City B] because I had passed a [exam]. Actually, I lived my entire life in [City B] but had moved to [City A] for my master's. We got married there, but then this opportunity came up, and we decided to move. Initially, this was a significant burden for me because she had to give up good professional possibilities in [City A]. But over time, this issue resolved itself, thank God. So, looking at the quality of day-to-day life, affection, and its demonstration, and the relationship with the children, I see few couples with similar or better relationships.

Speaker 1: I understand. And if you don't mind saying, how many girlfriends have you had before [Partner], and how does the quality of these past relationships compare? What were the differences?

Speaker 2: I wasn't a big dater. Before [Partner], I had about [1-5] girlfriends, and one of them was a long relationship, a [1-5]-year relationship with an engagement. It's hard to compare because of the ages and life stages. We were students, so financial issues were more challenging. But the previous relationship wasn't as good because I felt more restricted. I had to give up some things I wanted to do. When I met [Partner], I quickly fell in love with her because she was more similar to me in liking the same things and allowing me to be myself. It wasn't about permission but rather a more relaxed attitude, allowing me to express myself and enjoy my hobbies.

Speaker 1: Was it due to jealousy in the previous relationship?

Speaker 2: Not exactly jealousy, but intolerance of certain things.

Speaker 1: I see. And for you, what characteristics are necessary for a high-quality relationship versus a low-quality one? Two lists of characteristics?

Speaker 2: The first point is love or affection and how it is expressed. A more affectionate relationship is of better quality. Similarly, a relationship with more balance is better. Both partners need to give in to some things for harmony and satisfaction. The less you need to give up for harmony, the better. This applies to many aspects, like profession, behavior, self-expression, and relationships with friends and family. In my previous relationship, I had to give up a lot regarding these things. So, a relationship will have more good aspects if there is more balance in terms of giving in for harmony. Beyond this, expressing love and affection, having moments together, and enjoying being together are crucial. I know couples who can't stay home alone on weekends; they always need to go out with friends or family to feel good. But we enjoy being home alone, and this harmony at home is very important. The physical aspects of home life also matter, which can relate to financial conditions. We are privileged to have a comfortable home where we have everything we need, and being at home is very pleasant for us. This is also very important.

Speaker 1: And in your relationship with [Partner], were there moments of lower quality? Given so many years together, you must have gone through various situations.

Speaker 2: Yes, there were two significant moments. The first was when we moved to [City B]. She was finishing her master's and had few quality job opportunities, which made her very unhappy. She had always been very independent, even having her daughter at [16-20] and moving out at [16-20]. This was a very critical moment. The second was when she was in the [1st-5th] year of her PhD, and I took the opportunity to do my PhD too. Our son was two years old, and I was traveling weekly for my PhD. She was left with our son and a lot of work, and it created a lot of tension. Additionally, my brother, who was going through a separation, stayed with us for [6-10] months during this time. This period brought us to the limit of tension, which could have led to a separation if we hadn't passed through it.

Speaker 1: I see, that's a lot. I think you've covered a lot, but I'll ask this question because it's in the script. What is most important in a relationship for you? I know there's balance, love,

companionship, but what's most important? It can be something simple like watching a movie together on Friday night.

Speaker 2: I think the most important thing is partnership and sharing moments, whether at home, in a restaurant, or on a trip, and feeling good about it. There's something funny about my relationship with [Partner]. We are so in sync that, for example, on a Friday afternoon, I might think, "Today would be nice to order sushi," and then I come home, and [Partner] says, "Let's order sushi." It sounds like a joke, but it's true. This happens a lot. It's important to like doing similar things and feel good doing them with just the partner, without needing others around. Though we love meeting friends and family, we cherish our moments alone together.

Speaker 1: I see. I really liked that response. It makes sense with other things I'm studying. Now, a somewhat philosophical question. What does love mean to you? How would you define this feeling?

Speaker 2: In the context of a partner, right?

Speaker 1: Yes, yes.

Speaker 2: Because there are many kinds of love.

Speaker 1: Yes, there are.

Speaker 2: In a long-term relationship like ours, it's natural for the intensity to diminish over time, but there should still be a minimal amount of desire. The main thing, though, is taking care of each other. Not in a patronizing way, but in the small things, like making a favorite meal, helping with the morning routine, or ensuring the other person keeps up with important tasks. These small acts of care are vital. Harmony, a bit of desire and passion, taking care of each other, and enjoying being together—that's love for me.

Speaker 1: So for you, love in a relationship is essential? Could it be a relationship without love?

Speaker 2: I don't think so. Sometimes, it may turn into convenience, but that's different from love. A relationship without love might still function due to mutual benefits, but I don't have the experience to speak on that.

Speaker 1: I see. How do you know [Partner] loves you? What does she do that assures you of her love?

Speaker 2: It's the same things I do for her. Such things. We normally don't think like "What do I have to do tomorrow", right? Usually, it is like "What do we have to do tomorrow?" If it's nothing, then we say "So, I'll ride my bike" or "I'll go out and have a beer with my friends", right? There's always that, right? It's not about asking for permission, it's just trying to always reconcile things, right? And we do that a lot, right? We have that a lot and, well, the affection, right? Taking care of each other every day, right? Even our relationship with our children is something that, in a

way, shows how we love each other, right? Because another thing I believe is that children reflect a lot on the home environment. And when I say environment, I mean the environment, what they see, what they perceive, how we relate to each other, how we treat each other, right? I think this has a direct impact on how children grow up and how they, as adults, will live their own experiences. And I think our children, in this regard, are very much like us.

Speaker 1: Nice. And what are the challenges you currently face and how do you resolve them? Any conflicts, disagreements, anything in that sense?

Speaker 2: I think there's one thing, looking outward, right? What I mentioned about relationships with family and friends, sometimes, I consider myself a more conciliatory person. [Partner] is less so. [Partner] is a more combative person, right? And this, in my opinion, sometimes she doesn't like this trait of mine. Sometimes she wishes I were a bit more combative. But it's not that I'm passive, right? It's not that I am neglectful. I always prefer to avoid conflict, right? She doesn't; she has a shorter fuse. And we've been going through a period in [Country B] of a lot of polarization, especially with political issues. And we're surrounded by people who have a worldview very different from ours. And this is something you can handle up to a certain point because when there are certain things that you can't stand anymore, it's tough to see behavior, positioning, and opinions that are very different from yours and that make you feel bad. So, it makes me feel very bad to see people I care about, like siblings or childhood friends, behaving in ways that I can't tolerate. You understand what I'm talking about, right?

Speaker 1: Yes, I understand.

Speaker 2: So, this creates some tension because I prefer to withdraw. In my view, I won't interact with these people. For me, it's enough. It's like out of sight, out of mind. [Partner], however, confronts things head-on, on social media and all that. This sometimes creates tension because she wants me to be like her, but I'm not like her and I won't be. I've learned a lot from her over the years, absorbing and building values that I didn't have when I was younger. When I was a kid and a teenager, I reflected my family's and society's values, which were elitist, racist, sexist and homophobic. I've changed, and [Partner] played a big role in that. But now, I prefer to avoid confrontation, and she doesn't. So, this sometimes creates tension, especially when it involves family and long-time friends whom I don't want to cut ties with. That's what I would highlight as a point of tension. I think it's improved since last year.

Speaker 1: I see. And how do you resolve it?

Speaker 2: We resolve it by talking. Sometimes, there's a little argument, and we don't talk for a few days. But it doesn't go beyond that.

Speaker 1: I understand. And you mentioned that it's not so frequent anymore, that the worst period has passed, so now it's more relaxed but also not regular, right?

Speaker 2: Yes, it's not. But judging superficially, considering these 20-plus years, there have been very few serious episodes where we considered separating. Very few.

Speaker 1: I see. And besides talking and not having major conflicts, is there anything specific you do to maintain the relationship? I know you said you meet her needs when you see them, balance things, listen, and talk, but is there anything specific?

Speaker 2: No, I think that's it. I think empathy is a good word. Sometimes, she does things I don't like, not just about conflicts with others but in general. I try to react in a way that doesn't create more conflict, to find a way around it and maintain peace. Because I really hate conflict and bad feelings at home. If I'm upset with [Partner] or [Child], it's terrible for me. I can't work properly. So, I try to resolve it as quickly as possible. Sometimes it's beyond my control, but it's very important to me to avoid bad feelings with loved ones.

Speaker 1: I see. Do you believe your relationship is good for you? I think I know the answer, but I have to ask.

Speaker 2: Yes, it's very good. Very good. Despite moments of tension and having to compromise a bit here and there, it has made me a better person. I think that's very important.

Speaker 1: I see. This ties into the next question about how the relationship has changed you. You mentioned your values from your adolescence. Has anything else changed?

Speaker 2: That's already a huge change. It's funny because I'm an [Job] by training. I thought you were trained in administration. No, I'm a [Job] and have a doctorate in [Field]. So, I'm a [Job] in the administration program and in the undergraduate program too.

Speaker 1: I see.

Speaker 2: In that, I've learned a lot. I don't know if it's because [Partner] is a [Job], but the role of social relations in shaping us as people is something I've learned over these years. How the relationships we establish at home contribute to making me a better person than I was when I was finishing university. I had certain qualities that I think are good, but my virtues have certainly increased since being in this relationship.

Speaker 1: I see. Do you think the relationship has changed [Partner]? How has she changed over time?

Speaker 2: I don't know. It's hard to say because when you're in a relationship for so long, you notice changes less than those on the outside. Perhaps others would be better at answering that. She has certainly changed in some aspects, but I couldn't pinpoint them.

Speaker 1: Compared to the beginning of the relationship, do you notice any big changes now?

Speaker 2: Many changes, but many are consequences of life and the opportunities we've had and taken advantage of. Moving to different places, having children, financial situation changes, and opportunities to travel. We're going to do a post-doc together starting [Month] which will be a significant change for [6-10] months. Living without a car and being completely independent. Another change was when my mother-in-law moved in with us in [Year]. It was a significant

change in the household dynamic but less impactful than I expected. We also have a little dog now, which was a change. Now our grandchild is coming, which will be another change. Our daughter living in [Country C] was a change. Our life is full of changes, which we hope are always for the better.

Speaker 1: That's interesting.

Speaker 2: Adapting to change is crucial. I always say this to [Coworkers], making an analogy with physics. Newton's law of inertia says that to change your state of rest or constant motion, you need a force to move you. People of my generation are generally more resistant to change. But those who take advantage of opportunities and study usually have career opportunities. Sometimes these opportunities are stressful because they require you to break inertia. For example, instead of staying in [City A], I moved to [City B]. Change always brings some stress or discomfort. You need to adapt to make the change as good as possible.

Speaker 1: I see. Now, about security, do you feel safe in your relationship, both emotionally and physically, in your family environment?

Speaker 2: Yes, very safe.

Speaker 1: Now, I would need to show you a screen, but I'm on my cell phone, and my test didn't work, so I'll explain. I think you'll understand, if not, I'll try another way. On a scale from 1 to 9, where 1 is not at all true and 9 is completely true, how much do you agree with the following statement "[Partner] really listens to me"?

Speaker 2: Using the 9-point scale, right? I'd say 7.

Speaker 1: Why 7 and not 9 or a lower number?

Speaker 2: When it's something important, she listens better. But in day-to-day things, like [Social Media] messages, she sometimes takes a long time to respond. So, for me, that's a lack of listening. That's why I don't give a very high or very low score. When we need to make a decision, she usually listens.

Speaker 1: I see. Now, the same question, same scale, but a different statement. "[Partner] cares about my needs". From 1 to 9.

Speaker 2: 8.

Speaker 1: Why? With examples, please.

Speaker 2: Most of my needs, yes. Sometimes we have differences in things I like, and she thinks I shouldn't. For example, football. She thinks I'm too obsessed. She doesn't understand my need to suffer or go to a game. That's one of the few examples I can think of.

Speaker 1: I see. Let me check if I missed any statements. I think that's it. Now, two questions about your sex life. They're straightforward, not detailed, and if you don't want to answer, we can skip them. If you're okay with it, we'll proceed. It's quick.

Speaker 2: Sure, go ahead.

Speaker 1: Have you been sexually active recently? And recently is subjective, based on your concepts and experiences. No specific time frame.

Speaker 2: Yes.

Speaker 1: And how satisfied are you with your sex life, and why do you think you're very or not very satisfied?

Speaker 2: I'm satisfied but could be more satisfied.

Speaker 1: Do you want to explain why?

Speaker 2: It's mainly about frequency. As we age, it's different for men and women due to hormonal issues. That's basically it.

Speaker 1: I see. From what I've read, after a certain period, post-menopause, women's hormonal activity can increase their desire for sex. But I've read little about it, so I'm not an expert.

Speaker 2: Nowadays, there's a branch of medicine that works with hormone replacement therapy. So, it's easier to address.

Speaker 1: Yes, it's interesting to know these things. Now, the last question. Considering everything, how satisfied are you in your relationship, from completely dissatisfied to completely satisfied? How do you identify?

Speaker 2: Completely satisfied.

Speaker 1: And within completely satisfied, what percentage would you say? 100% or 80%?

Speaker 2: I'd say 90% because of the previous question you asked. It might be one of the things keeping it from being 100%.

Speaker 1: I see. That was the last question. I'm very happy with this interview. It was hard to get it, but thank you for answering everything in the best way. I loved talking to you; it reminded me a lot of my grandfather, who is fantastic, so I enjoyed it. I'll send the consent form on [Social Media]. Just check the boxes and write your full name since there's no way to sign digitally. We need it for the ethics committee. If you know any other couples with long relationships who could participate, please share their contact information with me. Thank you very much, [name].

Speaker 2: You're welcome, it was great talking to you too. I wish you success in your course and this research. Take care.

Speaker 1: Thank you, [Name]. Let me stop the recording before hanging up. Almost forgot. Bye.